Faith

By Eric Lane

(A confessional, simply represented by two chairs. FATHER, a priest in his forties to sixties, listens to MICHAEL 's confession. MICHAEL is in his twenties to thirties. Average looking.)

MICHAEL: . . . Bless me father for I have sinned.

FATHER: How long has it been since your last confession?

MICHAEL: Many years.

FATHER: Tell me your sins, my child.

MICHAEL: I have killed someone. *(A pause.)*

FATHER: Go on.

MICHAEL: Over and over. In my mind. Killed them for what they have done. And I'm scared.

FATHER: Scared of what?

MICHAEL: What will happen.

FATHER: **What** will happen?

MICHAEL: When it's no longer in my mind but me, actually not thinking but when it's time- Trying to believe, to find a reason not to-But less and less and wondering-

FATHER: Wondering what?

MICHAEL: Why?

FATHER: Wondering why what?

MICHAEL: How someone could have done this -- could have taken so much, when I trusted, believed . . . Why did I believe?

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INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *When a priest sexually abuses a child, the effects can be devastating.*

ACTOR 2: *The most trusted person imaginable suddenly does something that feels terribly wrong. It's a shattering experience.*

ACTOR 1: *In this selection, Michael (now a grown man) summons the courage to confront his abuser.*

ACTOR 2: *This performance is dedicated to the multitude of children betrayed by "pillars of the church."*

TOGETHER: *Faith by Eric Lane*

MICHAEL: I trusted, believed . . . Why did I believe?

FATHER: You were right to have faith.

MICHAEL: Not then. Not in him. He stole from me. Took things-

FATHER: Things.

MICHAEL: Not things. But important-Irreplaceable. Not things.

FATHER: Something closer to you.

MICHAEL: My youth. My joy. My innocence. He took my innocence.

FATHER: He hurt you.

MICHAEL: My soul. He took my soul.

FATHER: No one can take your soul. Only the Lord has that divine power.

MICHAEL: Took it. Pretending he knew things. Secrets. I didn't know.

FATHER: Your soul is still yours. No one can-

MICHAEL: Took it. When it wasn't his to take. To hold. Close. Me not knowing, thinking I should believe. That this is faith. That this is what God wants from me.

FATHER: You must forget.

MICHAEL: How can I forget?

FATHER: You must forgive.

MICHAEL: Forgive?

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FATHER: You must.

MICHAEL: No. No forgiveness. Not for this. Not him.

FATHER: The Lord forgives our sins.

MICHAEL: I'm not the Lord.

FATHER: Washes them away.

MICHAEL: Too easy.

FATHER: Offers salvation.

MICHAEL: Only words.

FATHER: And hope.

MICHAEL: No meaning.

FATHER: To those who pray.

MICHAEL: I'm out of prayers.

FATHER: Prayers are answered.

MICHAEL: I can't.

FATHER: Redemption.

MICHAEL: No.

FATHER: Salvation.

MICHAEL: Can't.

FATHER: Hope.

MICHAEL: None.

FATHER: Faith.

MICHAEL: Gone.

FATHER: Joy.

MICHAEL: I can't.

FATHER: Love.

MICHAEL: I can't forgive you. *(A beat.)* I can't forgive you.

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FATHER: Tell me your name.

MICHAEL: You don't get to ask. You don't get to do anything. ***You*** listen. And ***you*** pray. For what you've done to me.

FATHER: Who-

MICHAEL: Shut up. *(A beat.)* You don't even know who I am. Were there so many? You asshole. How many Hail Marys is it going to take to wipe away your sins? Now it's your turn. I want to hear it. Or I tell. Everyone. *(Silence.)* Now.

FATHER: What, my son?

MICHAEL: I am not your son. I never was ***your*** son. I want to hear your confession.

FATHER: I can't.

MICHAEL: Trust me.

FATHER: Only him.

MICHAEL: Where's your faith?

FATHER: My faith is in Jesus.

MICHAEL: Don't even try it.

FATHER: In the Lord Jesus Christ.

MICHAEL: Jesus Christ-

FATHER: In his divine mercy.

MICHAEL: Shut . . . up!

FATHER: I ask for his forgiveness.

MICHAEL: What about mine?

FATHER: Forgive me if I have sinned.

MICHAEL: "If." What kinda bullshit is that?

FATHER: If I have not seen-

MICHAEL: F*** you.

FATHER: Not followed-

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MICHAEL: How could I have followed?

FATHER: For what I am about

MICHAEL: What are you about?

FATHER: To do.

MICHAEL: I was five years old. Do you remember? I was five years old.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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